As a preliminary measure, Auckland ordered a naval flotilla to sail from Bombay to the Persian Gulf and occupy the island of Kharg off the coast southwest of Shiraz as a warning to the Shah. Then, while Emily organised amateur theatricals on one side of the drawing room – 'six plays for the benefit of the starving people at Agra' – on the other George turned his attentions to changing the ruler of Afghanistan.

His first hope was that Shah Shuja or Ranjit Singh would dispose of the troublesome Amir, so saving him the trouble of doing so. As Emily noted in a letter to her sister in England, 'Whenever we want to frighten our neighbours into good conduct, we have one sure resource. We always have a large assortment of Pretenders in store. They have had their eyes put out, or their children are in hostage, or the usurper is their own brother, or they labour under sundry disadvantages of that sort. But still there they are, to the good. We have a Shah Shuja all ready to *lacher* himself at Dost Mohammed if he does not behave himself, and Ranjit is ready to join us in any enterprise of that sort . . .'[111] In a letter to his masters in London Auckland put it more formally, writing that he was exploring the idea of 'granting our aid, in concert with Ranjit Singh, to enable Shah Shuja ul-Mulk to re-establish his sovereignty in the Eastern division of Afghanistan, under engagements which shall conciliate the feelings of the Sikh ruler and bind the restored monarch to the support of our interests'.[112]

So it was, on 10 May, that Macnaghten was despatched down to Lahore along with Lord Auckland's nephew and Military Secretary, Captain William Osborne, to sound out the Lion of the Punjab. Having learned the lesson not to economise on gifts, they carried a generous set of presents – 'A sword, the workmanship of which is reported to have been of high merit, two horses agreeable to ride and of a much esteemed English breed and to these I have added two Pistols specially selected by the Commander-In-Chief and understood by him to be admired by Your Highness.' For good measure, Auckland also sent several camel loads of alcohol for the bibulous Maharajah, who according to Emily 'had requested George to send him samples of all the wines he had, which he did, but took the precaution of adding some whisky and cherry brandy, knowing what Ranjit Singh's drinking habits are. The whisky he highly approved of, and he told Macnaghten that he could not understand why the Governor General gives himself the trouble of drinking seven or eight glasses of wine when one glass of whisky would do the same work.'[113] Some of the crates were